

Spiritual Formation for St Paisios

Brotherhood

¹³ And we impart this in words not taught by human wisdom but taught by the Spirit, interpreting spiritual truths to those who are spiritual.⁴ The natural (ψυχικός) person does not accept the things of the Spirit of God, for they are folly to him, and he is not able to understand them because they are spiritually discerned.¹⁵ The spiritual person judges all things but is himself to be judged by no one.¹⁶ “For who has understood the mind of the Lord so as to instruct him?” But we have the mind of Christ. **1Cor. 2:10-16**

But I say, ^vwalk by the Spirit, and you will not gratify ^wthe desires of the flesh.¹⁷ For ^xthe desires of the flesh are against the Spirit, and the desires of the Spirit are against the flesh, for these are opposed to each other, ^yto keep you from doing the things you want to do.¹⁸ But if you are ^zled by the Spirit, ^ayou are not under the law.¹⁹ Now ^bthe works of the flesh are evident: sexual immorality, impurity, sensuality,²⁰ idolatry, sorcery, enmity, strife, jealousy, fits of anger, rivalries, dissensions, ^cdivisions,²¹ envy,⁴ drunkenness, orgies, and things like these. I warn you, as I warned you before, that ^dthose who do⁵ such things will not inherit the kingdom of God.²² But ^ethe fruit of the Spirit is ^flove, joy, peace, patience, ^gkindness, goodness, faithfulness,²³ ^hgentleness, ⁱself-control; ^jagainst such things there is no law.²⁴ And those who belong to Christ Jesus ^khave crucified the flesh with its ^lpassions and desires. **Gal. 5:16-24**

St Paul in the Epistles outlines clearly the nature of our spiritual states, and how we ascend through the phases of spiritual maturity: from carnal to “psychic” to spiritual. Carnal means we give little thought to anything besides gratifying our senses. “Psychic” refers to the soul (psyche), where we may indeed have some awareness of God and spiritual life, but are distracted by our sensual passions, and thus, by the ego. The soul governs all the perceptions of the senses and all the thoughts of our mind. It analyzes all the data and rationally sorts through it. Thus, one may believe in God, but it is compartmentalized in the mind, and can also be rationally analyzed, as just one other topic to be understood. But because the

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passions still dominate and influence our ego-centric understanding, the way we comprehend spiritual life and reality is distorted. When we pursue an ascetic approach to life, by self-denial and taking up the Cross, we slowly begin to overcome egocentrism and the passions, and begin to perceive God and spiritual reality with our spiritual faculty, the nous. This takes time and is a long process.

Spiritual formation is the process by which we are guided toward that maturity, and the healing of our souls. Maturity and healing always go together. This is the very core of the teaching of Jesus: Repent! Repentance means transformation of your whole life, your body, soul and nous. An essential part of growth towards maturity is to master our passions. First, this means to clean up our life, reject the sins and passions that we almost automatically fall into, and embrace the virtues, to attain a clean heart and conscience. In short it means to embrace chastity, meaning not only to run from fornication as from a flame or a bomb, but also to cut out anything that brings up a carnal reaction: porn, unclean literature, dirty jokes or glances, anything that brings up carnal thoughts, images or sensations. We must embrace the spirit of peace and humility: freedom from anger, irritation, jealousy, envy, resentment. We must embrace self-denial and cut out pride, vainglory (and their opposites, self-hatred and self-pity), selfishness and self-aggrandizement. In short, if you're living with your girlfriend, move out; and sleeping together has to stop. If you are harboring resentment, anger and hatred, and seeking revenge, stop it. A basic rule is to never tempt yourself. Know that you are too weak to resist.

This process is energized by grace, which requires us to cooperate with God. All the passions begin as thoughts. The way we deal with them is *nepsis* and *apatheia*, watchfulness and dispassion. This means a constant watchfulness over our minds, to not let the provocative thoughts trigger a passionate reaction, and a rejection of that reaction if it begins; this method leads us to a degree of control over our mind, so that we can acquire inner peace, focus and attention. This is hesychasm, developed from the practice of prayer from the Egyptian desert monks in the 4th Century, up until now.

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There are three precepts of Orthodox spiritual life, which summarize this method: **Do not react; Do not resent; keep inner stillness.** Non-reaction means control over ourselves, and stopping ourselves from reacting to provocations externally as well as internally. Instead of having to react to every thought, word or deed, we take a moment to rationally analyze what just happened, decide if its worth a response, and rationally deciding how to appropriately respond. If we immediately and spontaneously react, it is controlled by our passions and can get us into all sorts of trouble. If we take a moment to rationally respond, controlling our emotions, we can likely avoid a fight. This is a proper use of our rational faculty. This is not simply in regards to external stimuli. It may be a thought that is the provocation, which we need to cut off before we do or say anything. Thus, it takes watchfulness over our mind to prevent a passionate reaction.

Resentment is about stored up pain and anger that has not been dealt with, and which we retain in our minds, often as anger and hatred. We justify our judgment and condemnation of the person who was the source of that provocation, judge him, hate him, and slander him. This, of course, is a grave sin, and we end up condemning ourselves. Resentment keeps us enslaved to our hurt feelings and ego, and even can become integrated into our ego, our self-concept. This is not helpful. When we bear resentment against anyone, the resentment pops out in many different forms, such as overreactions to otherwise mild provocations. Its like a reservoir of malice in our souls, a cancer that will destroy us if we don't resolve it. To resolve resentment, we need to forgive those who hurt us. We don't justify their actions, it was never "alright," never deserved. To forgive means to overlook the offense and realize that the other person is someone struggling just like you. You need to pray for them, ask God to forgive them, and to help you forgive as well. We also need to take responsibility for our own reactions, which are the sources of the resentment, and bring it to confession. The grace of God in absolution then heals the soul, if you let it. Then we must let go of the whole matter, and not continue to torture ourselves with it. Then we are free! And we take control of our own mind and heart, not surrendering to someone who hurt us perhaps years ago.

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Buried thoughts and memories of passions and trauma are just like resentments: they remain in our unconscious memory until something evokes them, and we begin to react. We all know what happens when we allow ourselves to entertain memories of carnal passions, or of relationships that went wrong, or traumatic events. Every image we have ever seen, every encounter with others for good or ill, every deep emotional trauma is just below the surface. All we need to do to create a reaction is to bring it to mind, and it changes our mood. This is not self-control, but rather its self-manipulation. The process is similar to resentment: we reject the thought and renounce it, ask God to remove it from your memory, and take it to confession.

This process of purification, *katharsis*, happens when we begin a real spiritual discipline. All sorts of thoughts, feelings, emotions, memories and resentment come vomiting up. It makes you feel like you are going backwards. But this is good (not pleasant, though!). This needs to happen in order to get rid of all the garbage stored up so that you can have a clear mind and pray without the distraction of thoughts. This is why it is so important that you have a father confessor to work with, who can help you deal with these thoughts and memories. The thoughts, especially buried resentments and traumatic memories, keep us imprisoned in our minds, our ego. It is impossible to approach spiritual awareness without this purification, and control over our passions. We may get little glimpses, but we are still stuck in the “psychic” level of consciousness.

The next aspect of this method is to attain to inner stillness. This is focused on the practice of prayer, especially the Jesus Prayer. The Prayer, “Lord Jesus Christ, Son of God, have mercy on me a sinner!” or the short form, “Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy on me!” is a discipline that brings us to deeper and deeper levels of communion with God. The Orthodox practice gets us beyond the Prayer into *Theoria*, contemplation or noetic awareness and vision, to the threshold of *theosis*, deification.

The goal of this ascent in prayer is the deification of our souls and bodies, the raising up of our spiritual awareness to knowledge of God. This is not rational objective knowledge about God, but rather the noetic experience of communion

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with God, which is true knowledge: union with God. Rational knowledge *about* God is all in our rational mind, mixed with our passions and emotions. True Knowledge of God is purely noetic and presumes the silencing of all thoughts.

When we are still stuck in our heads, our egos, passions, and thoughts, we use written and book prayers and think them in our heads. This is an important stage, in which we use the prayers of the Fathers of the Church to teach us to pray. Eventually, we learn to use the Jesus Prayer, and learn to focus our attention, to ignore thoughts, and to silence them. This is the battlefield of purification. This is still the preparation for noetic prayer. The first step is a couple of years; this second step, in which we go through the fires of purification, may last several years, before the prayer moves from the head into the heart. Once we have attained the prayer of the heart/nous, where our attention is focused in the heart and the conscious awareness of God, after a few hundred prayers the words trail off into total silence of the mind and heart. No words, images, thoughts, conceptual images, feelings etc. But our attention shifts to focus on God, not as object, but as Subject. As St Isaac the Syrian wrote, we become “conscious in God.” We do not move, except to breathe. We are simply present to God, and He to us.

We move from the Jesus Prayer to, as it were, the Prayer of Jesus, entering into union in Him by the Holy Spirit, as we participate in His prayer to the Father. This is where the transformation really begins, as He searches out the hidden places of the heart and heals them. Then He takes it from there, as the active partner in prayer. This is the transition to a spiritual state of being.

Spiritual formation is a total transformation, repentance (*metanoia*) in action. It presumes a dedicated cooperation with the grace of God, as we go through the stages of transformation. It is not quick, cannot be rushed. It takes years, but it is a never-ending process, going through death into the Kingdom. It demands that we “renounce the world and the things of this world” (1John 2:15). That does not mean we have to be monks (though that is the inspiration for multitudes of monks!) It applies to all Christians. The same with, “If you love father or mother more than me, you are not worthy of me...” (Matt. 10:37). It means that we need to surrender our whole life to Christ, no matter what the cost. We put Jesus Christ as

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the prime value and meaning of our life. When we do, and consciously maintain it, everything else falls into place, as we have as our only goal to be obedient to Him.

The context of our spiritual ascent is always the Church and participation in the Holy Mysteries. The deeper our experience of prayer, the more profound our experience of the Eucharist. They are parallel paths leading us to communion with God. They lead us to the same place. This movement is fulfilled when we are resurrected in Christ at the Last Day, radiant with His grace, and enter into the fulness of the Kingdom, where we will be like Him as He is.

Metropolitan Jonah

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Steps in Spiritual Transformation

Repentance: Metanoia

Spiritual formation is not a series of talks on how to balance your religious life with your social life, family life, sports and friends, work and play and going to church. That presumes a disintegrated, compartmentalized life, where the focal point is the gratification of my ego, my senses, my passions; with a little religion thrown in, to assuage the conscience. Spiritual formation is about overcoming the ego and making your spiritual life the defining criterion of every aspect of your life. It's not about having Jesus as part of your life. It's about making Him the center and the context of your life, ordering your life in which all things find their place and meaning in Jesus Christ. This is the process of repentance.

Jesus preached, "Repent, for the Kingdom of God is at hand." Repent is Μετανοείτε! This does not mean feel guilty and ashamed when you fall, and then say sorry. It means: "Be transformed in the renewal of your mind (νοῦς)" (Romans 12:2). It is the process of transformation not only of your behavior, and how you deal with sin. It means the transfiguration of your consciousness. It looks ultimately at Christ at His Second Coming, when we will be made radiant with His glory, which He has with the Father from all eternity. This is our goal, not to be a good boy and obey the rules; but rather, as the Desert Father of the 4th Century put it, "you can become fire." Real Christianity is not about being good and obeying the rules; it is the transformation of your mind, heart, soul and body, the deification of your whole life by the grace of the Holy Spirit. This is salvation, which starts in this world and goes on forever.

The question is, Do you want this? If you are going to be serious about your spiritual life, about being a Christian, this is the only path, the path of the Cross. It is the path of self-denial, of death to selfishness and self-centeredness, death to sin and death to ego. It means a radical restructuring of every part of your life, all your relationships, and all your values. But it means you become a new man, reborn in the Spirit. Jesus said, "If you love father or mother more than me, you are not

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worthy of me...and whoever does not take up his cross and follow me, is not worthy of me” (Matt. 1:37f).

Metropolitan Jonah